

Beat Patterns

How to read the grid

One bar of 4/4 is split into 16 steps. Count it out loud:

1 e & a 2 e & a 3 e & a 4 e & a

- The numbers (1, 2, 3, 4) are the **beats** — where you tap your foot.
- The "&"s are halfway between beats.
- The "e" and "a" are the in-between-in-between (sixteenth notes).

X = hit. **.** = rest.

The pop drum kit

- **Kick** — low "boom." Gives the song weight.
- **Snare / Clap** — sharp "crack" on beats 2 and 4. The part you clap along to.
- **Hi-hat** — "tss." Keeps time and adds energy.

Golden rule: keep the snare on 2 and 4. Change anything else.

1. Basic Rock / Pop

Works for almost everything.

	1	e	&	a	2	e	&	a	3	e	&	a	4	e	&	a
Hi-hat	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.
Snare	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.
Kick	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	X	.	.	.	.	.

2. Four on the Floor

Dance, disco, EDM. Kick on every beat.

	1	e	&	a	2	e	&	a	3	e	&	a	4	e	&	a
Hi-hat	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.
Clap	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.
Kick	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.

3. Half-Time

Feels slower and heavier, even at the same tempo. Snare only on beat 3.

	1	e	&	a	2	e	&	a	3	e	&	a	4	e	&	a
Hi-hat	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.	X	.
Snare	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.
Kick	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.

4. Ballad

Slow and spacious. Hi-hat on beats only.

	1	e	&	a	2	e	&	a	3	e	&	a	4	e	&	a
Hi-hat	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.
Snare	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.
Kick	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.

5. Trap

Hip-hop and modern pop. Fast hi-hats, half-time snare.

	1	e	&	a	2	e	&	a	3	e	&	a	4	e	&	a
Hi-hat	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Snare	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.
Kick	X	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	X	.	.	.	.

6. Dembow (Reggaeton)

Latin pop. The snare pattern is the signature.

	1	e	&	a	2	e	&	a	3	e	&	a	4	e	&	a
Snare	.	.	.	X	.	.	X	.	.	.	.	X	.	.	X	.
Kick	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.	X	.	.	.

Make the chords move too

Play your progression three ways. Which fits your song?

- **Whole notes:** one hit per bar, let it ring. → ballad
- **Quarter notes:** hit on 1, 2, 3, 4. → driving
- **The push:** hit on 1, then on the "&" of 2, then hold. Say it: **ONE** two **AND** three four. → modern pop

On ukulele, these become strum patterns, plus two more (island strum and the chuck). See [Ukulele Songwriter's Guide](#).

My beat: _____ **My strum:** _____